



BUYERS' GUIDE

ESTYLE

EARPHONES: The Cheap, The Neat And The Visionary



Dillin Anand is a senior assistant editor at EFW. He is B.Tech from University of Calicut, currently pursuing MBA from Christ University, Bengaluru

Earphones are one of those rare categories where you can find products representing the most mundane of devices, as well as the most bleeding-edge jewels of technology. As a result, it is easy to get lost between the umpteen models lined up between the inexpensive Philips SHE series that cost ₹ 150 and a pair of Bose QC 20's billed at ₹ 25,000.

What to look out for when buying earphones

As a guide to help you pick out the best pair of earphones, explained below are the top five elements that you must factor into your purchase decision.

Sound reproduction. It is obviously going to get tough to deliver great sound when earphones come with drivers the size of a fingernail.

Frequency. To get a good idea of the sound quality, check the frequency range shown on the package. It may range from 15Hz to 20kHz—the lower the starting number, the better the bass. Note: Human ear cannot detect anything above 20kHz.

Impedance. You need to check the impedance of your earphones; the higher the impedance (measured in ohms), the clearer the music you hear. If you are going to use your earphones without an amplifier (via a smartphone, for example), go for 32-ohm or lower.

Noise isolation. How important is music for you over the surroundings? The answer to the question will decide how much noise isolation you should be looking for in your earphones. Of course, there are people who use noise-cancellation earphones to get some peace at work instead of whiling away time with music. Normal earphones that hang right outside your ear canal have very little noise cancellation, while the in-ear phones are fitted enough to enable you to enjoy

some natural noise isolation.

There is also the other end of the spectrum—people who want to hear ambient sounds around them with greater clarity along with their music. These are the ones who should go for either a practical Bose QC20 or a Bragi Dash for superhuman hearing abilities.

Value for money. "There is no such thing as a free lunch," goes the saying. If the product is insanely cheap, then the manufacturer has found a way to cut some corners. The question is whether you are prepared to deal with the consequences or lack of features on inexpensive earphones.

It is really a matter of how much certain features are worth to you. For instance, in-ear phones retailing at ₹ 800 offer better noise isolation than standard earphones. However, if you travel a lot around the world but simply cannot stand the drone of airplane engines, then an active noise-cancelling earphone costing ₹ 15,000 might not seem like a hefty sum anymore. The same goes for other value-added features like magnified ambient sounds and Bluetooth connectivity.

Ergonomics. Depending on the kind of usage you have planned for your earphone, you may need to get ones that offer better ergonomics. If you run, hit the gym or battle your way through hordes at Delhi Metro on a daily basis with earphones on, you will need ones that do not fall off at the slightest jerk. Unfortunately, there is no easy way to judge which earphones fit best unless you try them on.

Some of the better earphones in the market come with multiple-size earbuds. In fact, ergonomics is such a big issue that firms such as Revols have come out with earphones that have tips that mould to the unique shape of your ears in 60 seconds for a truly-custom fit.

Durability. Do you remember the classic Samsung and Apple comparison from a few years back, where plastic Samsung phones

Wireless earphones

